

Lecture 2: Talking About Film Music

EVALUATING A SCORE:

How do we talk about what we hear?

Key Terms and Concepts:

Diegesis:

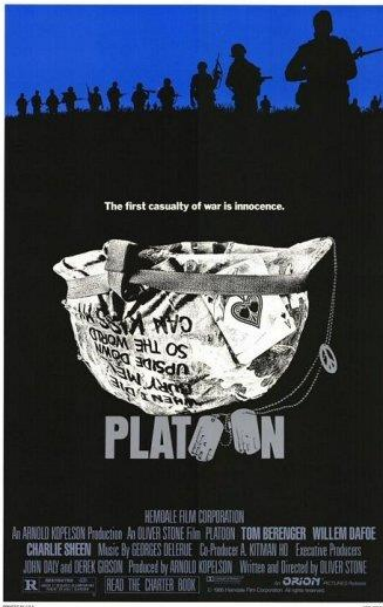
- The world of the narrative. All characters, events, etc depicted, suggested, or described.

Diegetic Music / Source Music:

- music whose source is within the Diegesis.
- heard both by the characters within the narrative and the film audience.
- also known as “**source music**,” “direct music,” or “foreground music.”
- Functions include: establishing time and place, creating a sense of “realism and immediacy,” offering ironic comment.

Nondiegetic Music / Score:

- heard by the film audience only.
- Referred to as the “**score**,” “underscore,” or “background music.
- Normally originally composed for the specific film (original score).
- May also include pieces of **preexisting music** selected to accompany the scene.
- Example of preexisting music: **Platoon** (1986) Composer: George Deleure, also includes Samuel Barber’s *Adagio for Strings* (1938). Also used in **The Elephant Man** (1980) and **Sicko** (2007).



Example: Platoon (1986) Using the “Adagio For Strings” by Samuel Barber

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QEv3zzKyIFO>

Adapted Score: all preexisting music *adapted* for the film.



Example: The Sting (1973) Music of Scott Joplin, adapted by Marvin Hamlisch.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FCfflhAHbT0>



Scott Joplin



Compiled Score: all preexisting music, used *without adaptation*. **2001: A Space Odyssey** (1968), Compiled from the works of R. Strauss, J. Strauss, etc...

Describing the Music:

Style:

- what type of music has the composer chosen?
- what type of instruments?
- how do these choices relate to the film as a whole?

Example:



Restoration (1995) Composer: James Newton Howard

Score is part original part adapted, based on the work of Henry Purcell

Example: Restoration (1995) Music by James Newton Howard, based on a theme by Henry Purcell

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=psna8iUfYWQ>

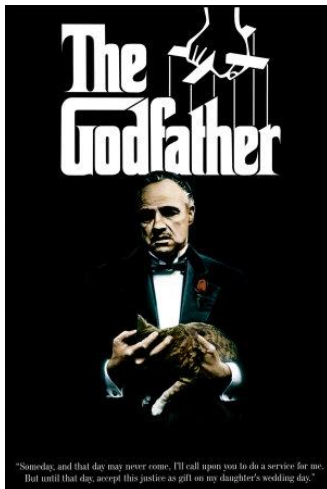


Local Hero (1983) Composer: Mark Knopfler.

- Knopfler developed melodies similar to Anglo Celtic folk music.

Example: Local Hero (1983) Music by Mark Knopfler

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=hm-ZHUfCTwk>



The Godfather (1972) Composer: Nino Rota

Concept:

Most film music will fall somewhere between two extremes:

1. Playing the Drama

- music attempts to reinforce primarily emotional elements within the narrative.

2. Hitting the Action

- music accents visual events.

How To Train Your Dragon (2010)

Original score composed by John Powell

Example: “Test Drive” from How To Train Your Dragon:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZDyEERuK31Y>

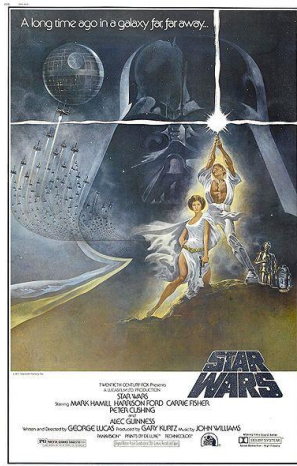


- (00:39) main theme as they begin the dive – builds excitement (PD)
- (00:51) overhead shot - music “swells” as they fly through the arch (PD-HA)
- (00:58) HA as they bump into the rock
- (01:20) HA as the cheat sheet becomes loose. Music becomes nightmarish as they fall (PD)
- (01:53) HA as the wings open – return to first theme as they regain control. (PD)
- (02:01) Hiccup throws away the cheat sheet (HA-PD) - grandest statement of main theme at this point – why?

Musical Characteristics:

1. Melody or Theme

- Considered the most “recognizable” music element for western ears.
- Do characters, objects or situations have a particular melody associated with them?
- German Opera composer Richard Wagner – Leitmotif.
- Thematic Transformation – themes (leitmotif) undergo constant variation in response to narrative development



Example: Thematic Transformation

Star Wars (1977) Music composed by John Williams



2.

Tempo or Pulse:

- How does the speed of the music influence the “tempo” of the narrative? On-screen action, editing, sound design.
- Music is unexpected for a battle scene.
- Also an excellent example of music blurring the line between source music and score.



Example: **The Return of the King** (2004)

Composer: Howard Shore

3. Harmony

- The major scale
- Consonant / dissonant: Orderly / Chaotic: Tonal / Atonal
- What do these differences in consonance and dissonance suggest about events in the Diegesis?

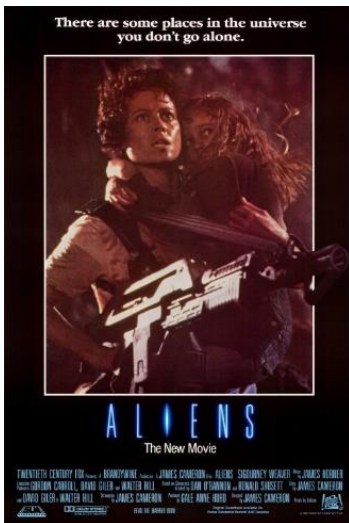
Examples:



Highly Consonant: *Main Theme* from **Cider House Rules** (1999) Composer: Rachael Portman



Blend of Consonant and Dissonant: *Yes* from **Meet Joe Black** (1998) Composer: Thomas Newman



Dissonant: *Bishop's Countdown* from **Aliens** (1986) Composer: James Horner

The End (For This Week)